17

THE MAKING OF A NEW WOMEN'S VOTE

Gender, Politics and Hindutva

In October 2007, I landed in Ahmedabad to cover Narendra Modi's second chief-ministerial election campaign for a television channel. The ECI had just announced the election dates for Gujarat, the official campaign was yet to start, and we were catching up on local gossip. The journalist Brajesh Kumar Singh, then Ahmedabad bureau chief at Zee News, turned to me and said, 'What campaign have you Delhi journalists come to cover? Modiji has already finished his campaign.' He must have noticed the incredulous smile that these big-sounding political claims tend to bring to my face. So he added quietly, 'You may not believe it, but did you know Modi in the past year has held women-only public meetings in almost every district in Gujarat? The official campaign is the official campaign and it will start now, but do you understand the importance of what he has done with these women's meetings? His real campaign and support base at this level was long done before Congress woke up to the official campaign.'[1]

Government records showed that the Gujarat chief minister had personally presided over twenty-seven mahila sammelans (women's meetings) in various districts between 10 March and 20 September 2007 in the months leading up to the election announcement.[2] These women's empowerment meetings were organised through